

RSO Leader Onboarding Guide

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Overview

This guide is intended to support students who are leading or planning to lead a Registered Student Organization (RSO). Whether you are new to a role or looking to improve your approach, this resource provides practical guidance to help you succeed.

This guide covers key areas such as funding, reserving rooms, recruitment, and strategies for how to run an RSO. You may navigate the document using the **hyperlinks in the Table of Contents**. Each section includes a **Too Long; Didn't Read (TL;DR) summary** for a quick overview of the most important points.

Securing Funding

TL;DR: Most RSOs get their funding through SGA using the [Engage Finance Tool](#). Submit a bill, wait for approval, and then submit a purchase request before you spend any money.

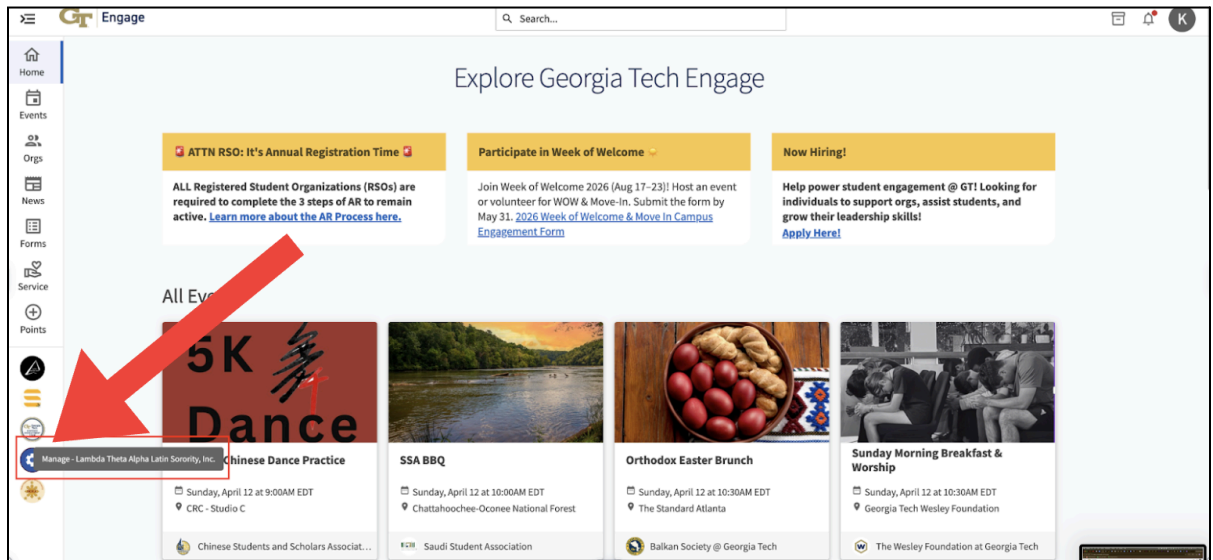
How SGA Funding Works

SGA funding comes from the student activity fee and is used to support RSO events and operations, covering allowable costs such as food, supplies, equipment, travel, and other expenses that directly benefit Georgia Tech students.

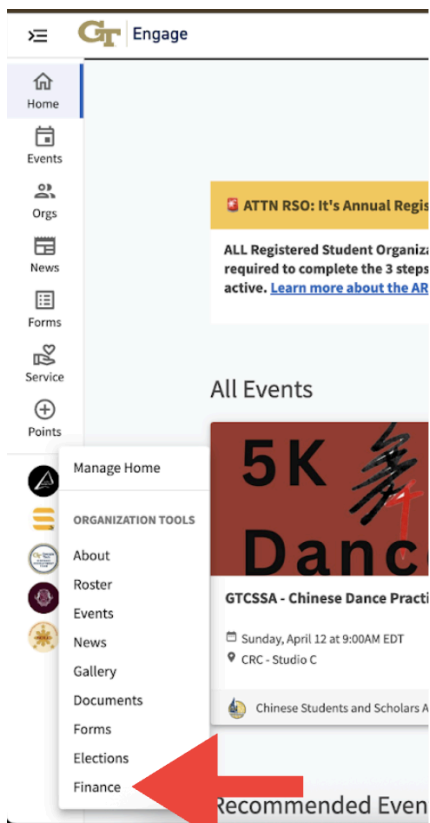
1. Submitting a Bill
 - a. This is where you request funding for your event. You need to include itemized costs and justification for the expense.
2. Waiting for Approval
 - a. Your request will be reviewed by the Joint Finance Committee
 - b. Funding is NOT retroactive, so only spend money after approval.
3. Submitting a Purchase Request
 - a. After approval, you need to submit a purchase request to use the funds allocated.
 - b. This is done through the Finance tool on Engage

Accessing the Finance Tool

1. Head to <https://gatech.campuslabs.com/engage/>
2. Click on your organization's profile image

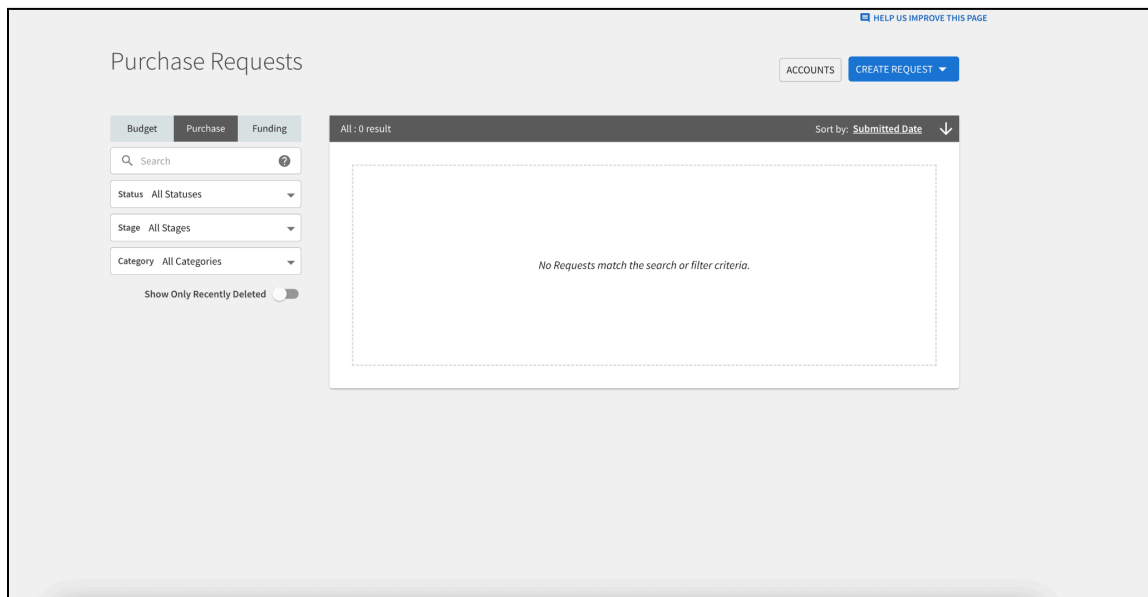


3. Once you click the gear icon, a dropdown menu should pop up
4. Click into the 'Finance' option to access the Finance Tool.

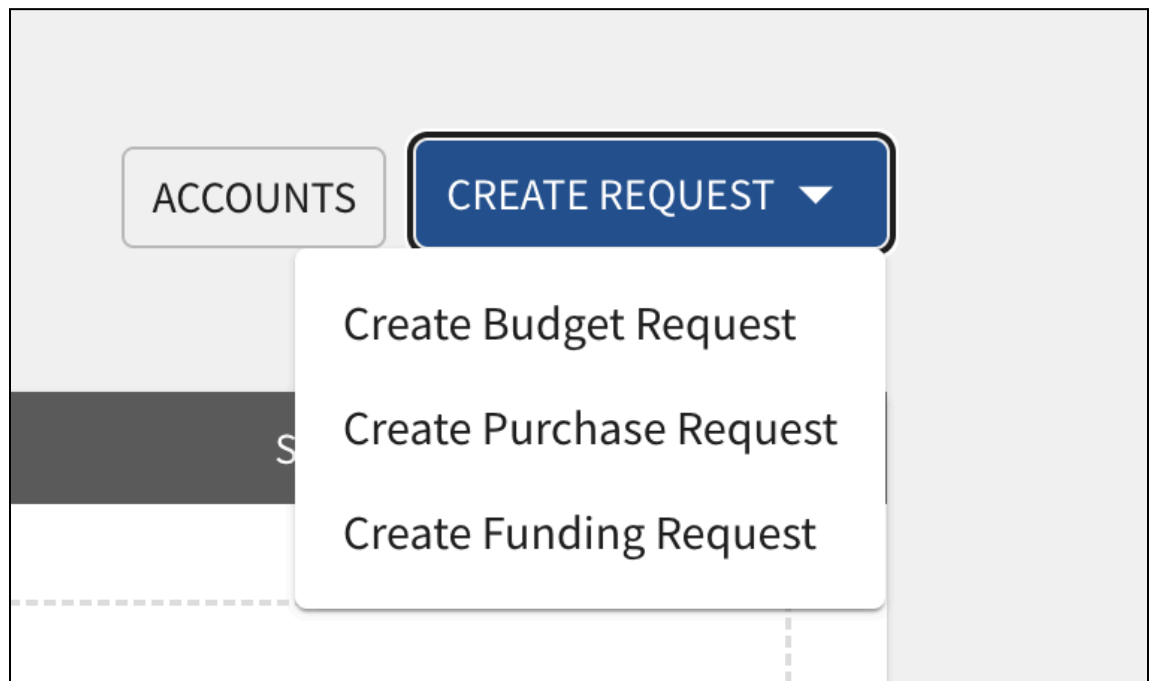


Submitting a Budget Request

1. Once in the finance tool, it will open to this page.



2. Click on the create request button.
 - a. From the drop down choose:



- i. Create Budget Request: this will be to submit a bill
 1. You should create your budget request around 30 days before the event takes place

- ii. Create Purchase Request: this will be to spend the allocated funds
 - 1. You need to create this *after* the budget request was approved
 - 2. Make sure your receipts include:
 - a. Itemized list of the items you purchased
 - b. Price of each item and total cost
 - c. Vendor name and the date of purchase
 - d. Proof of payment
- iii. Create Funding Request: this will be to transfer money made from a fundraiser or other donations into the account
 - 1. Handling fundraiser payments
 - a. Cash/Check
 - i. Record the total amount collected and what it was for
 - ii. Bring funds to SOFO to deposit into your organization's account
 - iii. Keep the deposit receipt for your records
 - b. Online payments
 - i. Use Marketplace (uStore) or other approved GT systems
 - ii. Payments are automatically deposited into your organization's account
 - c. Venmo/Zelle/Cashapp
 - i. Transfer the money into your bank account
 - ii. Turn the money into cash or check
 - iii. Deposit in the SOFO office and they will process it for you

Parents Fund

The Parents Fund is another funding opportunity available to all RSOs and provides funding for events, travel, food, marketing, and more. Parents Fund is more flexible and grant-based, while SGA funding is more structured and requires strict approval and allowable cost guidelines.

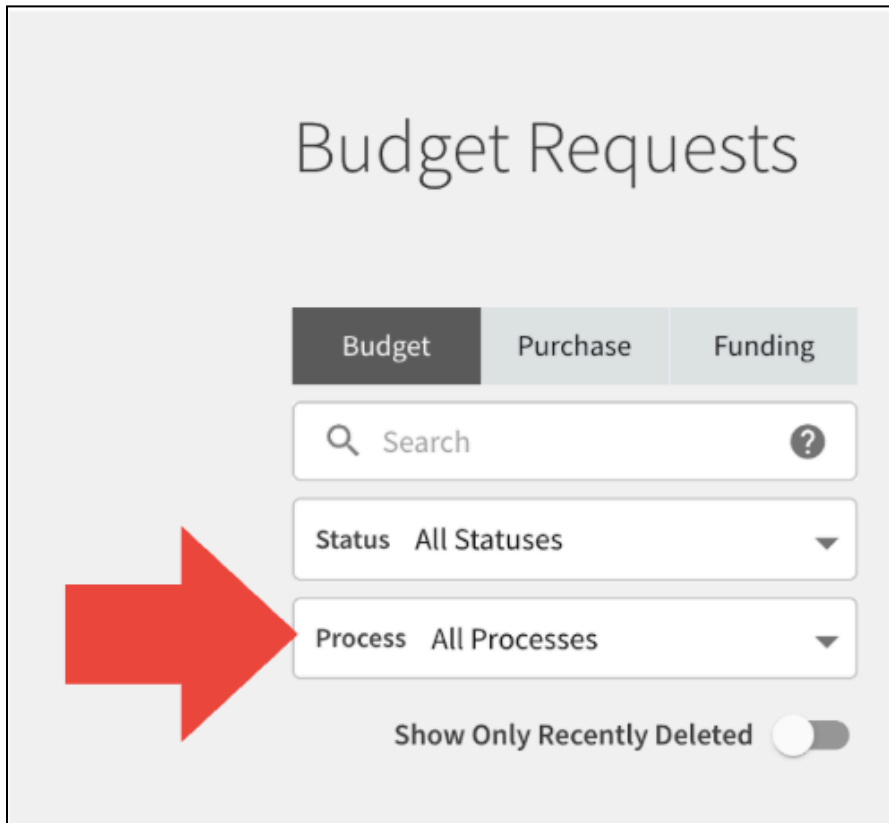
This fund supports:

- Student engagement

- Leadership development
- Community service
- Cultural and campus events

Applying to Parents Fund

1. Navigate to the Engage Finance Tool's Budget section



The screenshot shows the 'Budget Requests' interface. At the top, the title 'Budget Requests' is displayed. Below the title are three tabs: 'Budget' (selected), 'Purchase', and 'Funding'. Under the 'Budget' tab, there is a search bar with a magnifying glass icon and a question mark icon. Below the search bar are two dropdown menus: 'Status All Statuses' and 'Process All Processes'. A large red arrow points to the 'Process All Processes' dropdown menu. At the bottom, there is a toggle switch labeled 'Show Only Recently Deleted'.

2. Click into the Process drop down and select the Parents Fund application for the current semester.

Budget Requests

BudgetPurchaseFunding

All : 1 result | Export

Status All Statuses

Process

- ✓ All Processes
- 3M RSO Micro-Grant
- Alcohol and Other Drug Funding
- ANAK Operational Support Fund
- ANAK Sustainable Development Goals Fund
- Parents Fund Grant Application Fall '25
- Parents Fund Grant Application Spring '26
- SGA Bills Process FY26
- SGA FY26 Budget Request
- SGA FY27 Budget Request
- SGA Rollover FY25 Budget and Bills
- SGA's Mental Health Joint Allocation Committee Request

3. Submit the following
 - a. An event description
 - b. 1-2 page explanation
 - c. Line-item budget
4. Applications only open once each semester and you can request up to \$10,000 per semester and can include multiple events in one application.

Additional Funding Options

ANAK Funding

- Provides up to \$500 for operational needs including meetings, supplies, or smaller events
- For newer or smaller organizations that might not get SGA funding
- Applications are submitted through Engage and reviewed on a rolling basis

Georgia Tech Student Foundation (GTSF)

- Awards over \$40,000 each semester to different student organizations for larger and unique initiatives
- Funding is provided as a reimbursement, meaning that the funds will be reimbursed with proof of purchase

3M RSO Micro-Grant

- \$250 - \$500 for student-lef events focused on well-being, engagement, and belonging
- Applications are submitted on Engage and reviewed on a rolling basis

Tips for Success

1. Submit requests early to ensure you meet all the deadlines
2. Be specific and include a clear budget breakdown
3. Don't spend money before approval
4. Keep all receipts and documentation

Reserving On-Campus Spaces

TL;DR: Go to <https://git.emscloudservice.com/web/> to reserve rooms. The [Exhibition Hall](#) has many great reservable spaces.

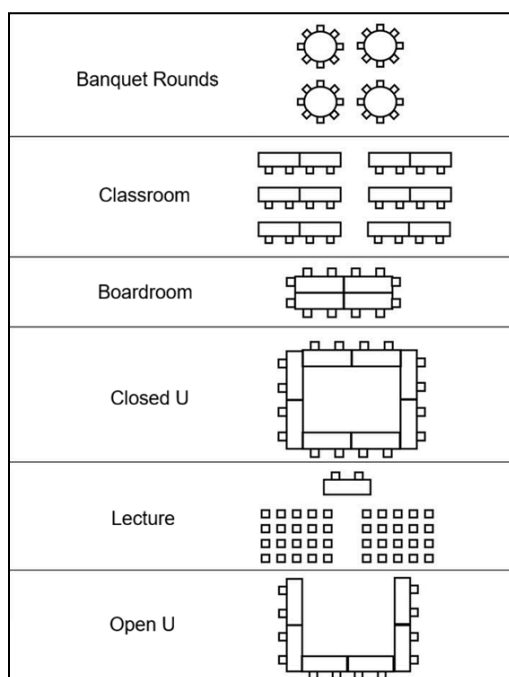
RSOs can reserve rooms and tables on campus for free. For brevity, this guide will not explicitly cover reserving table spaces, but they are reserved in much the same way rooms are reserved. You can find more information on reserving table spaces [here](#).

Selecting a Space

All reservable spaces are listed [here](#). The best general-purpose spaces are [classrooms](#), [Student Center rooms](#), and [Exhibition Hall rooms](#). Both the Student Center and Exhibition Hall are open from 7:00am – 11:00 pm seven days a week, but every classroom building has its own hours.

If you reserve an Exhibition Hall room, you can **specify a room layout** (e.g., banquet round tables, classroom style, team tables). You cannot do this for Student Center rooms or classrooms; however, the Student Center rooms cover a wide variety of layouts, so you may find a layout you like in the Student Center.

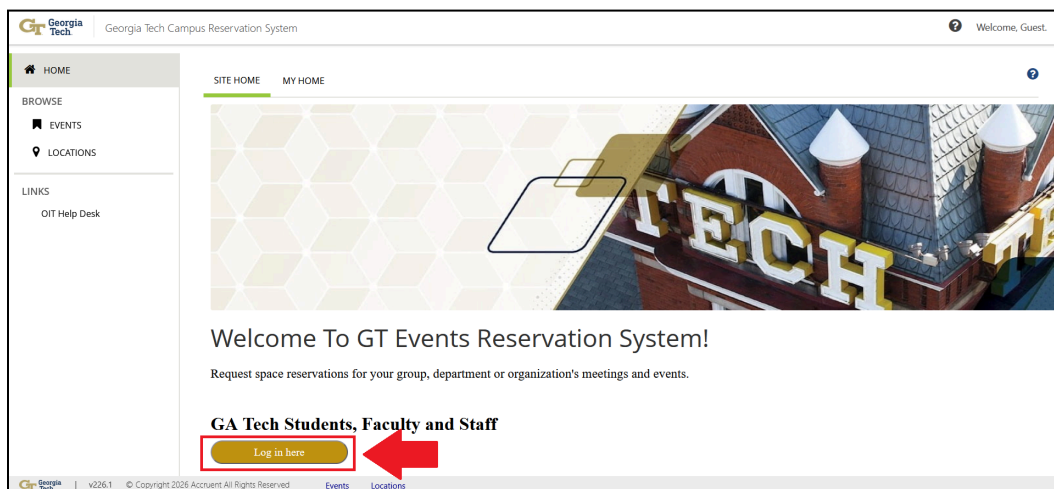
Unfortunately, Georgia Tech does not have a list of its room layouts. Below is an image that shows all room layouts except Career Fair and Exhibition.



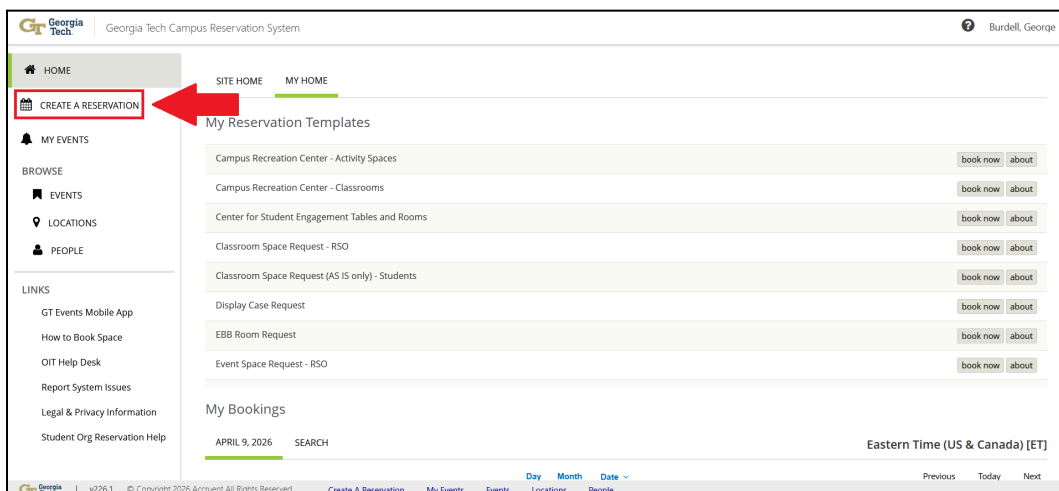
It is likely that the room you want to reserve will already be reserved. Therefore, it's important that you (a) **reserve rooms as soon as possible** and (b) **have multiple rooms** you can pick if you don't get your first choice. Student Center and Exhibition Hall rooms can be reserved up to a year in advance, while classroom spaces can be reserved starting at 8:00am on the first Monday of August, December, or April for the Fall, Spring, and Summer semesters respectively.

How to Reserve a Space

1. Go to <https://git.emscloudservice.com/web/>
2. Log in using this button

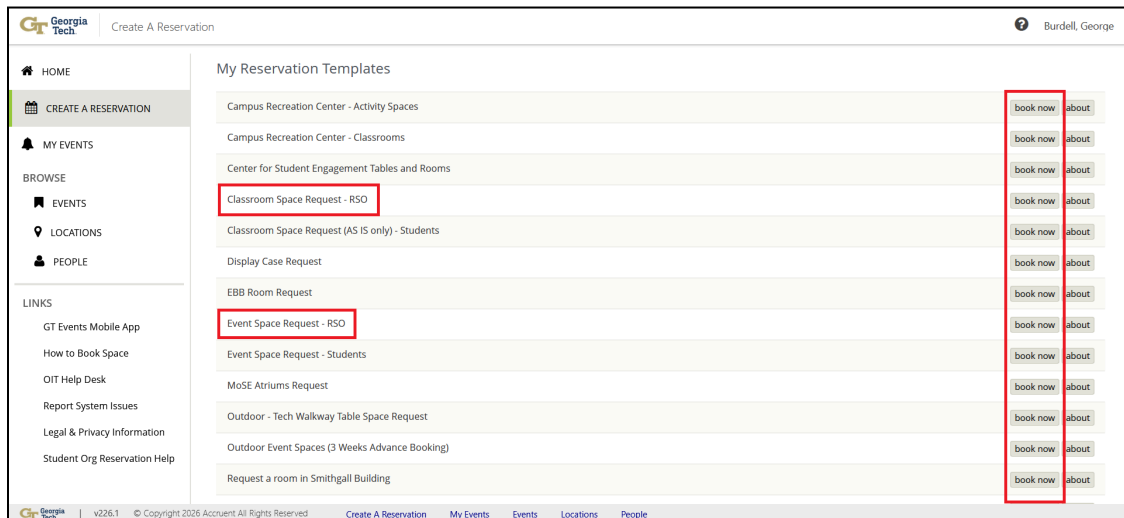


3. Click on "Create A Reservation"

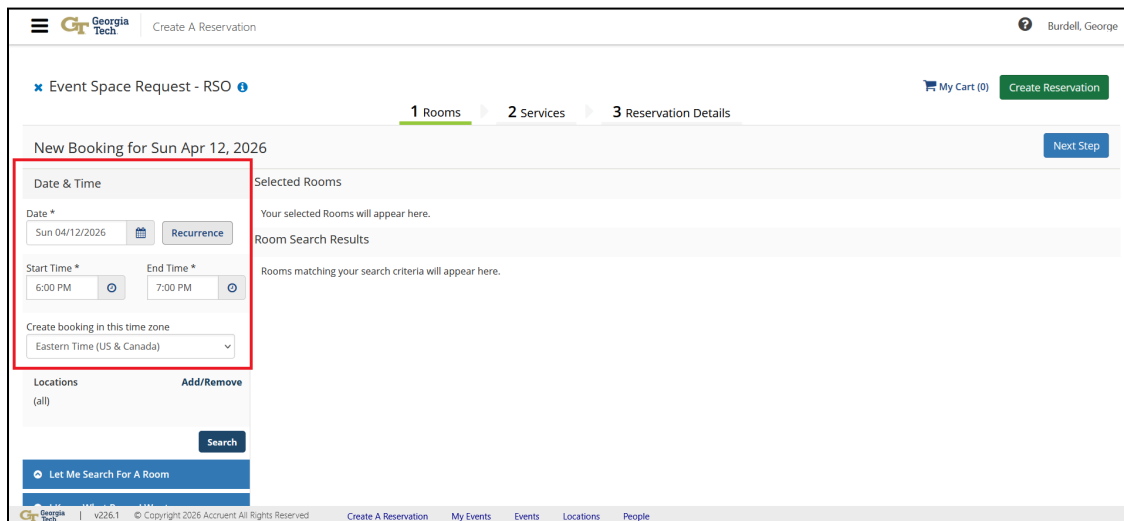


4. Select the type of space you want. Here, "Classroom Space Request" refers to the aforementioned classroom spaces while "Event Space Request" refers to both Student Center and Exhibition Hall rooms. Once you've

selected a type of space, click on “book now.”



5. Select the date and time you want to create a reservation for.



- If you'd like this reservation to repeat, click on the “recurrence” button and follow the prompts. This is good for weekly meetings.

6. Click on the "Search" button

The screenshot shows the 'Create A Reservation' page for Georgia Tech. The page is titled 'Event Space Request - RSO'. It has a progress bar with three steps: '1 Rooms', '2 Services', and '3 Reservation Details'. The '1 Rooms' step is active. The page is for a 'New Booking for Fri Jan 1, 2027'. On the left, there are fields for 'Date *' (Fri 01/01/2027), 'Start Time *' (12:00 PM), 'End Time *' (1:00 PM), and 'Locations' (all). A red box highlights the 'Search' button, and a red arrow points to it. The right side of the page shows 'Selected Rooms' and 'Room Search Results'.

7. Click on the "List" tab

The screenshot shows the 'Create A Reservation' page for Georgia Tech, now displaying the 'Room Search Results' section. The 'List' tab is highlighted with a red box and a red arrow. The page shows a table of rooms available for booking on Fri Jan 1, 2027. The table has columns for room name, capacity, and time slots. The rooms listed are 'Alumni House (ET)', 'The Guthridge Lounge', 'The Griffin Ballroom', and 'Brittain T Room (ET)'. The 'List' tab is selected, and the 'Schedule' tab is also visible. The 'Search' button is highlighted with a red box and a red arrow.

8. Scroll through the spaces that show up. Pick the one you want to reserve, and press the green plus button next to it.

The screenshot shows the 'Create A Reservation' page for Georgia Tech. The 'Rooms' tab is selected, displaying a table of available rooms. A red box highlights the green plus button next to the first room, '1101 Atrium Klaus'.

Room	Location	Floor	TZ	Cap	Filter Match
1101 Atrium Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	250	
1116 East & West Seminar Room Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	150	
1116 East Seminar Room Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	75	
1116 West Seminar Room Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	75	

9. In the popup window that appears, input the expected number of attendees and, if given the choice, the desired setup type (room layout).

The screenshot shows the 'Attendance & Setup Type' popup window. It prompts the user to enter the number of attendees and select a setup type.

Attendance & Setup Type

To continue, please enter the number of attendees and desired setup type for this Room.

Number of Attendees *

0

Setup Type *

Add Room **Cancel**

10. Click on the "Next Step" button

Georgia Tech | Create A Reservation | Burdell, George

Event Space Request - RSO

1 Rooms | 2 Services | 3 Reservation Details

New Booking for Mon Jan 25, 2027

Date & Time

Date *
Mon 01/25/2027

Start Time *
12:00 PM

End Time *
1:00 PM

Create booking in this time zone
Eastern Time (US & Canada)

Locations
(all)

Selected Rooms

Room Search Results

LIST | SCHEDULE

☐ Favorite Rooms only.

Find A Room

Search

Room	Location	Floor	TZ	Cap	Filter Match
1101 Atrium Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	250	
1116 East & West Seminar Room Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	150	
1116 East Seminar Room Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	75	
1116 West Seminar Room Klaus	Klaus Event Spaces - Open 8 AM to 5 PM	First Floor	ET	75	

Rooms You Can Request

Setup Types

Let Me Search For A Room

Search

Next Step

11. If you're reserving an Exhibition Hall room, add any equipment to the room that you'd like (e.g., chairs, tables, lectern)

Georgia Tech | Create A Reservation | Burdell, George

Event Space Request - RSO

1 Rooms | 2 Services | 3 Reservation Details

Services For Your Reservation

Next Step

Exhibition Hall Equipment

- AV Equipment
- Furniture
- Miscellaneous
- Exhibition Hall Equipment

Billing Information

Billing Reference

Services Summary

12. Click on the "Next Step" button

The screenshot shows the 'Services' step of the reservation process. The breadcrumb trail is '1 Rooms' > '2 Services' > '3 Reservation Details'. The 'Next Step' button is highlighted with a red box. The page displays 'Services For Your Reservation' with a list of equipment: AV Equipment, Furniture, Miscellaneous, and Exhibition Hall Equipment. A 'Billing Information' section is also visible.

13. Fill out the required fields in the Reservation Details page

The screenshot shows the 'Reservation Details' step. The breadcrumb trail is '1 Rooms' > '2 Services' > '3 Reservation Details'. The page contains several required fields marked with an asterisk: 'Event Name', 'Event Type' (dropdown), 'Group', and '1st Contact' (dropdown). There is also a text area for 'Additional Information' with a prompt: 'Please provide a brief description of your event and any planned activities.' The 'Create Reservation' button is visible in the top right corner.

14. Click the "Create Reservation" button

This screenshot is identical to the previous one, showing the 'Reservation Details' step. The 'Create Reservation' button is now highlighted with a red box, indicating the final step to complete the reservation.

Helpful Links

- Make a reservation: <https://git.emscloudservice.com/web/>
- Guide for reserving spaces:
<https://studentcenter.gatech.edu/start-your-reservation>
- List of reservable spaces:
<https://studentcenter.gatech.edu/reservable-spaces>
- Information on reserving table spaces:
<https://studentcenter.gatech.edu/tabling-spaces>

Recruitment and Advertising

TL;DR: [This site](#) contains links to various on-campus advertisement opportunities, both physical and digital. RSOs can reserve digital advertisement spots on screens in the John Lewis Student Center at no cost. Your ad's design should be eye-catching, but not overwhelming.

Attracting and Retaining Members

The key to any successful RSO is its members. Maintaining solid membership requires a balance of recruiting new members and inspiring current members to stick around.

Recruiting new members is done via some form of advertisement, including but not limited to: digital signage, physical flyers, word-of-mouth or events. When creating visuals to represent your organization, you want them to catch the eye, but not so much as to overwhelm your audience. Georgia Tech's [VGDev](#) does a great job of this (see [here](#)), with their flyers and many others displayed all around campus. The following are some avenues you can use to advertise your organization.

1. **Digital screens** in the John Lewis Student Center or Georgia Tech CRC. You can fill out [online applications](#) to have your organization's advertisements displayed at these locations which see many students come and go each day.
2. **Flyers** can be posted on indoor bulletin boards in many buildings across campus. Policies for posting on bulletin boards may vary across buildings so be sure to check with each location.
3. **Tables** can be reserved along Tech Walkway (next to Tech Green), to allow prospective recruits to chat with members from your organization. Follow [these](#) steps, making sure to select "Outdoor - Tech Walkway Table Space Request" as your space. Additionally, refer to [this site](#) for more information on reserving table spaces; it has important information such as the fact that table spaces do not come with tables.
4. **Events** are a great way to bring people together and get them excited about your organization. Creating events can be done via [Engage](#). Events can be hosted in-person or virtually, if needed refer to [this guide](#) for help.

Retaining members is primarily about providing a positive experience and a sense of community. The form this takes varies across organizations, but there are some key principles to keep in mind. These are known as the [GRAPE](#) principles.

1. Growth - Members should have the opportunity to learn or make improvements in some area
2. Recognition - An organization that is widely recognizable and has a positive reputation is easier to market
3. Achievement - Providing some goals or benchmarks (over various time periods) allows members to recognize their progress and have a sense of accomplishment
4. Participation - Allowing members to take part in organizational activities and have an impact can be overlooked. It is important to let members at all levels participate without imparting too much individual work.
5. Enjoyment - Being in an RSO can offer a reprieve from the stress of Georgia Tech student life. Providing avenues for members to enjoy themselves through organizational activities is crucial to creating a positive environment.

By adhering to these principles, you are more likely to provide a positive membership experience to encourage continued participation in your RSO.

Utilizing Advertisement Spaces

The plasma screens at the John Lewis Student Center are a great place for on-campus advertising. See steps below to get started.

1. Go to <https://studentcenter.gatech.edu/advertise-our-spaces>

2. Make sure your advertisement meets listed formatting requirements and click on the 'Submit Your Ad' button to access the request form.

Plasma Promotions

Plasma Promotions are a great way to get your message to thousands of students, staff, and faculty everyday! See below for details on locations, pricing, and best practices. To submit a plasma advertising request, click the link below. Before submitting, please be sure that your ad aligns with the submission standards outlined below. Ads that do not follow these standards will not be posted. For questions, please contact Event Services at **404.894.2828** or email EventServices@studen.gatech.edu.

Submit Your Ad

Locations

- Advertisements will be displayed on the plasma screens in the John Lewis Student Center and Stamps Commons and the Exhibition Hall.
- Please allow at least 3 business days for processing from time of submission to advertisement begin date.
- All advertisements will be displayed without sound.

Format Requirements

- The file containing the ad must include the group's name.
- Ads must be in landscape orientation.
- Ad dimensions must be at least 1460 x 830 pixels. Please be aware we are not able to reshape your graphic(s).
- The file containing the ad must be JPG or PNG format.
- All ad submissions must follow the above submission standards or they will not be posted.

Pricing

Registered Student Organizations	FREE
GT Departments/Colleges	\$40 / week
External Clients/Off Campus Groups	\$100 / week

3. Fill out the request form and check out your advertisements in person!

Helpful Links

1. General Digital Advertising:
<https://comm.gatech.edu/campus-resources/advertising>
2. Flyer Posting Information:
<https://www.studentcenter.gatech.edu/sccec-posting-guidelines-and-practices>
3. Engage Event Guide:
<https://studentengagement.gatech.edu/using-engage-gt/creating-engage-event>
4. Canva Flyer Design Guide:
<https://www.canva.com/learn/the-ultimate-guide-to-flyer-design/>

Leadership Best Practices

TL;DR: Running a successful RSO means building systems that keep your organization organized, communicative, and sustainable over time.

While the previous sections outline the core functional processes required to running a RSO, this section focuses on how to manage these responsibilities effectively over time on a day-to-day and week-to-week basis. Many of the challenges new RSO leaders face come not from a lack of information, but from difficulty staying organized, communicating clearly, and maintaining consistency. The following strategies provide a framework for building systems that support these tasks and help your organization run smoothly throughout the semester.

Use Systems that Everyone Can Access

Strong RSOs don't rely on individuals remembering everything, they **use tools to stay organized**. Here are examples of tools that could be helpful for your organization (you do not need to use all of these, they are just ideas):

- **Slack or Discord** → daily communication and announcements
- **Google Drive** → store budgets, documents, and leadership materials
- **Google Sheets** → track budgets, attendance, and planning
- **Notion** → central hub for everything (tasks, docs, timelines)

Having **one consistent system** provides a level of organization that helps everyone stay on the same page with equal access to information. This is especially important to new leaders, as relying on memory or informal communication can quickly lead to missed deadlines or confusion.

Plan Early and Stay Organized

Leadership should start working on some basic logistic tasks at the start of each semester to get everyone on the same page, and to prevent chaos later down the road. Examples of such tasks that could be good to start early include:

- Create a **basic budget plan** (events, food, marketing, etc.)
- Outline **key events and goals**
- **Reserve rooms as early as possible**

Keeping this information in a **shared system** ensures the whole team is aligned. Planning early allows you to secure resources before they become limited and reduces last-minute stress when events approach.

Build a Strong Exec Team

You should not be doing everything yourself. A strong leader allows others to help when necessary and this also sets the rest of the organization up to live beyond your tenure.

- Assign **clear roles and responsibilities** (finance, marketing, events, etc.)
- Use **shared tools** (Google Docs/Sheets) so that everyone has visibility
- Hold **short, consistent check-ins** to stay on track

Good **delegation** makes your organization more scalable and less stressful. For example, a funding chair can manage funding requests, while a marketing chair handles promotion, allowing each role to focus on a specific area. Common roles may include president, vice president, treasurer, marketing chair, events chair, and recruitment or membership chair. This helps with organization, and giving others responsibility encourages engagement.

Focus on Membership Experience

Retention matters just as much as recruitment. Putting the quality of member experience at the forefront of all programming will add more value to the club as a whole, and will keep people wanting to come back. Some ways to do this are:

- Create a **welcoming environment** for the first meeting (have everyone introduce themselves!)
- Offer **consistent, valuable events** by:
 - Establishing a **predictable schedule** (e.g. same day/time each week)
 - Ensuring each event has a **clear purpose or takeaway** (learning, networking, social, etc.)
 - Gathering **member feedback** and adjusting programming accordingly
- Give members ways to **get involved early**

People stay when they feel **included and see value**. This can include interactive meetings, opportunities for leadership, and creating a space where members feel comfortable returning each week. While attendance is important, remember that members have other commitments on their plates, and be an understanding leader.

Communicate Clearly and Often

Members will be looking to leadership for information on weekly meetings, and upcoming events. Be sure to send this information out in an organized, consistent way so that members know what to expect and can plan accordingly.

- Use **one main platform**
- Send **regular updates and reminders**
- Keep messaging **simple and consistent**

Confusion is one of the biggest reasons organizations struggle. For example, sending a weekly message with meeting details, upcoming events, and reminders can significantly improve attendance and engagement. This will help with setting expectations, and ensuring that members have to go through minimal effort to be notified of upcoming events or action items.

Plan for Leadership Transition

One of the biggest failure points of RSOs is **poor handoff**. A strong leader is always thinking about who will come after them, and should be planning for this throughout the semester.

- Keep all documents in a **shared, organized folder**
- **Document processes** as you go
- **Involve younger members early** so they're prepared to lead

A **well-documented organization** is easier to sustain. Starting this process early ensures that future leaders are familiar with responsibilities before taking over. This gives the organization longevity and consistency between semesters.

Bottom Line

Running a successful RSO is not about completing tasks, it's about creating **repeatable systems and strong team structures** that make those tasks easier to manage over time. By using centralized tools, planning ahead, communicating clearly, and documenting processes, you can reduce confusion, improve member experience, and ensure continuity between leadership teams. These strategies allow your organization to move beyond simply operating and instead build a **sustainable, well-functioning community**.

FAQs

Q: When should I submit a funding request?

A: Submit funding requests as early as possible, ideally several weeks before your event. Funding is not retroactive, so you should never spend money before approval.

Q: What happens if my funding request is denied?

A: You can:

- Revise the funding request and resubmit with clearer justification
- Adjust your event budget
- Explore alternative funding

Q: How far in advance should I reserve rooms?

A: Reserve rooms as soon as possible, many popular spaces fill up weeks or months in advance. Always have backup options.

Q: What if a room is already taken?

A: Choose an alternative space or adjust your event time. Flexibility is important, especially during busy parts of the semester.

Q: Should we use Slack, GroupMe, or Discord?

A: There is no single “correct” platform stack, what matters most is choosing one primary platform and using it consistently to avoid confusion. One should do their own research to determine which platforms work best for their organization’s needs.

Q: What do I do if people stop showing up?

A: Low attendance is often a communication or engagement issue, not just a lack of interest. Some actions you can take are:

- Re-evaluate meeting format and value
- Improve communication/reminders
- Ask members for feedback